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Mock interview panel brief: Deji Kolawole - Business Analyst

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MOCK INTERVIEW PANEL BRIEF

Business Analyst

You are interviewing Deji Kolawole.

Hi chinedu onwe,

You have been assigned to run this mock interview. This email includes the private interviewer brief: questions, strong-answer notes, and grading rubric. Do not share it with the candidate before the session.

When: Thursday 20 August 2026, 13:00 UTC
Candidate: Deji Kolawole
Company: Office for National Statistics (ONS)

Job advert

The Office for National Statistics is the UK's largest producer of official statistics, covering economic, social and demographic topics — the value of the UK economy, the size and characteristics of the population, and indicators of inflation, employment, earnings, crime and migration.

These Business Analyst roles sit in the newly established Economic Statistics Improvement (ESI) directorate, which delivers the Survey and Economic Statistics Improvement Plan and sets the strategic direction for how the UK's economic statistics are developed, modernised and enhanced. The Architecture, Design and Data Sources (ADDS) division sits within ESI, in the Surveys and Economic Statistics group. Three Business Analysts are being recruited at the start of their BA careers.

As a Business Analyst you would understand and analyse user and business needs, and make sure outcomes align with the service vision and business strategy by linking current and future business models to the business architecture. You would work with solution architects and developers to analyse system capabilities, develop use cases and ensure solutions meet business needs; challenge constructively as a critical friend; and lead communication with stakeholders through design, build and delivery.

Responsibilities include: reviewing existing system capabilities and developing use cases and information models; defining business process improvements and building business cases so decisions can be made on benefits; communicating project scope and shaping the product backlog; eliciting functional and non-functional requirements; developing analysis models with traceability to business objectives; delivering at pace using agile principles; working with business and solution architects so the wider architecture is considered; assisting decision makers with the information they need; promoting a

culture of assurance and security; quality assuring test solutions; and participating in the Business Analysis community. The role works under the direction of other Business Analysts and requires the ability to self-manage a workload.

Candidates should be willing to work towards BCS (ISEB) accreditation in a module contributing to the diploma in Business Analysis or Solution Development, or hold appropriate business analysis experience. Based at the Newport or Titchfield site.

Essential criteria (all assessed at 'Working' level):

- Business Analysis — apply structured approaches to identify, investigate, analyse and communicate complex business problems and opportunities within a defined project; analyse business goals, objectives, functions and processes to support the definition of requirements; conduct options analysis, assess feasibility and operational impact, quantify potential benefits and contribute to business case development.
- Business Modelling — model elements of the business with limited direction, understanding how changes affect processes, systems, data, roles and responsibilities.
- Business Process Improvement — analyse and evaluate processes to find problems and opportunities; design, prioritise and facilitate improvements; validate them through testing.
- Requirements Definition and Management — identify, analyse, challenge and validate business and user requirements; co-ordinate and review prioritisation; use appropriate requirements management life cycle methods.
- Stakeholder Relationship Management — identify important stakeholders, communicate clearly and regularly, tailor communication to their needs, build consensus, and use evidence to explain decisions.

Selection process: two stages. Stage 1 is the application — work history, CV, skills, experience and a personal statement of no more than 1250 words giving evidence against each essential criterion, ideally using STAR (Situation, Task, Action, Result). Success Profiles behaviour examples are not required at application stage. Stage 2 is a Microsoft Teams interview assessed against the Success Profiles framework, covering the advertised behaviours — Delivering at Pace, Changing and Improving, Making Effective Decisions, Working Together — and the technical skill Stakeholder Relationship Management. Candidates also give a 5-minute presentation, with the topic sent one week beforehand, assessed against Changing and Improving.

The post requires Security Check (SC) clearance, which needs three consecutive years' UK residency immediately prior to applying. Visa sponsorship is not offered.

Topics covered

- Business Analysis (structured investigation, options analysis, business cases)
- Business Modelling (processes, systems, data, roles)
- Business Process Improvement (identify, design, validate)
- Requirements Definition and Management (elicitation, prioritisation, traceability)
- Stakeholder Relationship Management (tailored communication, consensus)
- Civil Service Success Profiles behaviours & STAR answers
- Agile delivery and the product backlog
- 5-minute presentation on Changing and Improving

Private question plan

1. To start, tell us briefly about yourself and what has led you to apply for this Business Analyst role.

Suggested asker: Jonathan Agu Nwokeka

Focus: Candidate introduction / motivation

Strong answer notes: A strong answer gives a concise 60-90 second profile: relevant background, transferable BA/data/process experience, why this role is the logical next step, and one clear link to ONS/ESI. It should not be a full life story or a repeat of the CV.

2. Why do you want to work for ONS, and why this Economic Statistics Improvement area specifically?

Suggested asker: Seun Ayoola

Focus: Motivation / organisational fit

Strong answer notes: Connects ONS outputs and public value to the candidate's own motivation, then links ESI to modernising economic statistics, improving data sources/processes, and supporting better decisions. Avoids generic public-sector or 'good organisation' answers.

3. What experience or strengths would make you effective as a Business Analyst at the start of your BA career?

Suggested asker: chinedu onwe

Focus: Role fit / strengths

Strong answer notes: Names two or three strengths with evidence: structured investigation, stakeholder communication, requirements thinking, process improvement, data awareness, or self-management. Should be honest about being early-career while showing readiness to learn under direction.

4. You're asked to look at a slow, manual process in one of our survey teams, and the ask is vague — 'it takes too long'. Walk me through how you'd structure your investigation.

Suggested asker: Mercy Chibueze-Igwe

Focus: Business Analysis (Working)

Strong answer notes: Names a structured approach — clarify the problem and its scope, map the as-is process, gather evidence/data on where time actually goes, identify root causes, then options — rather than jumping to a solution. Should mention agreeing scope with the sponsor before analysing.

5. Tell me about a time you improved a business process. How did you know the change actually worked?

Suggested asker: Jonathan Agu Nwokeka

Focus: Business Process Improvement / Changing and Improving

Strong answer notes: Full STAR with the candidate's own actions. Crucially names a validation step — before/after measure, test, or user feedback — not just 'everyone said it was better'. Result should carry a number or a concrete outcome.

6. How would you model a change where a new data source affects a process, the systems that support it, and who's responsible for what?

Suggested asker: Seun Ayoola

Focus: Business Modelling (Working)

Strong answer notes: Names specific modelling techniques (as-is/to-be process maps, BPMN, use cases, data flow, RACI) and shows understanding that a change ripples across process, system, data and roles — not just 'I'd draw a diagram'.

7. Two stakeholders give you conflicting requirements and both say theirs is the priority. What do you do?

[Suggested asker: chinedu onwe](#)

Focus: Requirements Definition and Management / Working Together

Strong answer notes: Goes back to the underlying user need and business objective rather than picking a side; names a prioritisation method (MoSCoW, value vs effort) and describes bringing both parties together with evidence to reach consensus. Should mention escalating only after trying to resolve it.

8. How do you tailor the way you communicate the same piece of analysis to a developer, a senior sponsor, and a survey operations team?

[Suggested asker: Mercy Chibueze-Igwe](#)

Focus: Stakeholder Relationship Management (Technical skill)

Strong answer notes: Gives three genuinely different framings — detail and acceptance criteria for the developer, benefits/risk/decision needed for the sponsor, day-to-day impact for operations — with a real example, not a generic 'I adapt my style'.

9. You've analysed three options for a change and leadership needs to choose. How do you help them make that decision?

[Suggested asker: Jonathan Agu Nwokeka](#)

Focus: Making Effective Decisions

Strong answer notes: Describes options analysis with costs, benefits, feasibility, operational impact and risks laid out comparably; gives a recommendation with reasoning rather than dumping options; acknowledges the do-nothing baseline and how benefits were quantified for the business case.

10. Tell me about a time you had several pieces of work competing for your time and a fixed deadline. How did you manage it?

[Suggested asker: Seun Ayoola](#)

Focus: Delivering at Pace

Strong answer notes: Shows self-management — how work was prioritised, what was renegotiated or descoped, who was kept informed — and ends with the deadline met or a deliberate, communicated trade-off. Avoids 'I just worked late'.

11. The role asks you to be a 'critical friend'. Describe a time you challenged a decision or a colleague's approach, and how it landed.

[Suggested asker: chinedu onwe](#)

Focus: Working Together / constructive challenge

Strong answer notes: Challenge is evidence-based and framed around the user or business need, delivered privately or in the right forum; describes the relationship afterwards, showing challenge without damage. A weak answer is either conflict-avoidance or an adversarial win.

12. Tell me about a time you worked with people whose priorities, working styles, or background were different from yours. How did you keep the work moving?

[Suggested asker: Mercy Chibueze-Igwe](#)

Focus: Culture / inclusion / Working Together

Strong answer notes: Shows respect, listening, and adaptation without becoming vague. A strong answer names the difference, what the candidate changed in their approach, how they kept communication clear, and the outcome for the team or user.

13. Describe a time you received feedback you did not fully agree with. What did you do next?

[Suggested asker: Jonathan Agu Nwokeka](#)

Focus: Culture / feedback / self-awareness

Strong answer notes: Shows openness without passivity: listened first, checked the evidence, asked clarifying questions, acted on the useful part, and followed up. Avoids defensiveness or pretending all feedback is automatically correct.

14. ONS work affects public trust. What behaviours would you expect from yourself when handling uncertainty, mistakes, or pressure?

[Suggested asker: Seun Ayoola](#)

Focus: Culture / integrity / public trust

Strong answer notes: Connects culture to behaviour: transparency about uncertainty, early escalation of risks, evidence-based decisions, careful handling of data, and willingness to correct mistakes. Should not be a generic 'I am honest' answer.

15. You've been given a presentation topic a week before interview and five minutes to deliver it, assessed on Changing and Improving. How would you structure those five minutes?

[Suggested asker: chinedu onwe](#)

Focus: Presentation / Changing and Improving

Strong answer notes: Plans to a time budget with a clear arc — the problem and why it matters, the proposed improvement, how it would be tested and what the benefit is — and finishes inside five minutes. Should mention rehearsing to time and preparing for follow-up questions.

16. What do you understand about what ONS does, and why does improving economic statistics matter?

[Suggested asker: Mercy Chibueze-Igwe](#)

Focus: Organisational context

Strong answer notes: Names concrete ONS outputs (inflation, employment, GDP, population and migration estimates) and connects them to real decisions government, the Bank of England or the public make with them — not a generic 'I want to work in the public sector'.

17. What is one development area you would need to work on to succeed in this role, and how would you address it?

[Suggested asker: Jonathan Agu Nwokeka](#)

Focus: Self-awareness / development

Strong answer notes: Picks a real but manageable development area, explains why it matters for BA work, and gives a specific plan such as seeking feedback, shadowing experienced BAs, practising requirements documentation, or working towards BCS learning. Avoids fake weaknesses or anything fatal to the role.

18. What questions would you like to ask us about the role, the team, or how success would be measured?

[Suggested asker: Seun Ayoola](#)

Focus: Candidate questions / role curiosity

Strong answer notes: Asks thoughtful questions about first-6-month priorities, how BAs work with architects/developers/survey teams, what success looks like at Working level, or how the BA community supports early-career analysts. Avoids questions answered directly in the advert.

Scoring rubric

- Delivering at Pace (Behaviour)**

Shows they organised their own workload, kept momentum under a real deadline, and finished — with the outcome stated, not just the effort.

- **Changing and Improving (Behaviour)**

Identifies an inefficiency, proposes a specific improvement, and says how the improvement was tested or validated rather than just suggested.

- **Making Effective Decisions (Behaviour)**

Weights options against evidence and constraints, states the trade-off accepted, and explains how the decision was made defensible to others.

- **Working Together (Behaviour)**

Collaborates across business and technical teams, and can challenge constructively as a 'critical friend' without damaging the relationship.

- **Stakeholder Relationship Management (Technical)**

Identifies who the important stakeholders are, tailors communication to each, and uses evidence to build consensus and explain decisions.

- **STAR structure & evidence**

Answers land as Situation, Task, Action, Result with the candidate's own actions and a measurable impact — not a description of what the team did.

Open interviewer workspace

You received this because you were assigned as an interviewer for a Qode Clarity mock interview.